

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN KIRIBATI

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the reefs, lagoons, and ocean of Kiribati — but this guide must begin honestly, because Kiribati is a poor, remote, low-lying atoll nation where the hardest destructive decisions are driven not by greed but by genuine need, and there is no community victory to point to. Kiribati is a scattered republic of atolls in the central Pacific, home to around 120,000 people, with an ocean territory larger than India and more tuna caught in its waters than in those of any other nation on earth — more tuna caught in its waters, year after year, than in those of any other nation anywhere on earth — and with fishing licences supplying more than seventy percent of the government's revenue. In that context, the country's most consequential recent decision was to reverse one of its own greatest conservation achievements: in late 2021 the Cabinet decided to reopen the Phoenix Islands Protected Area — some four hundred thousand square kilometres of ocean, an area the size of California, a UNESCO World Heritage site and once one of the largest marine reserves on earth — to commercial fishing, because the fund meant to replace the lost revenue had raised only a fraction of what was promised, and a poor nation could not afford to keep so much of its ocean closed. A poor nation, in the end, could not afford to keep so much of its ocean closed to the fishing that sustains it. This guide will not pretend that opposing such a decision is simple, or that the community has beaten it; it has not.

The Kiribati story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the evidence, the coalition, and the pressure on the deciders — pressed together. The second is distinctly I-Kiribati, and it is what gives this guide its real, if difficult, force. **In a poor atoll democracy where development need is real, conservation survives only if it is made to serve the people — and a community's levers are its own customary institutions of collective decision, its democratic process, and the international partners who can make protecting the ocean pay.** That combination — the maneaba, the nation's ancient meeting-house of collective governance; the elected Assembly; and the World Heritage system, the regional bodies, and the conservation partners who can fund and reward protection — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because the lesson of the Phoenix Islands is precisely that conservation that does not meet the people's needs will not last.

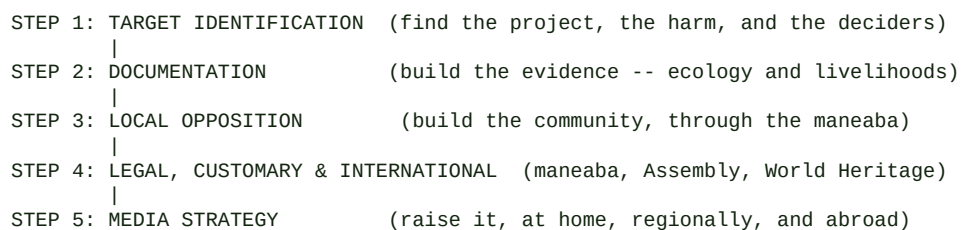
But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **Here, the obstacle is often genuine poverty and genuine sovereignty, not villainy.** The government reopened the marine reserve because a low-income nation depends on fishing revenue and the conservation funding fell short — a real dilemma, not a scandal — and it rightly resists having conservation imposed on it from outside as a kind of neo-colonial demand. The historical devastation of Banaba, whose phosphate was strip-mined until the island was left barely habitable and its people resettled far away, is a warning of what extraction can do; but it is also a reminder that a poor island's resources are often all it has. This guide does not pretend the choices are easy or the community has prevailed. What it shows is how, in a poor and sovereign atoll democracy, a community can use its maneaba, its democracy, and its international partners to defend the ocean and the reefs — not by lecturing a struggling nation, but by helping make protection pay, and by insisting that development be done without destroying what the islands depend on.

Most communities do not know HOW to make protection serve the people rather than oppose them. They see a marine reserve reopened, a reef dredged, a lagoon degraded, or seabed mining proposed, and either accept it as the price of survival or oppose it in ways that pit conservation against the nation's needs — and lose. They rarely bring the matter to the maneaba as a collective decision, rarely press the Assembly, rarely reach the partners who could make protection financially worthwhile. The gap between the ocean defended and the ocean lost is here, above all, a gap of method — the method of making conservation and the people's needs one cause, through the community's own institutions.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Kiribati reality as it is, which is poor, remote, sovereign, and democratic. It is written for the person who sees a reef, a lagoon, a fishery, or an island threatened — by reversal of protection, by damaging development, or by extraction — and who wants to know what can be done in a nation that must weigh every acre of ocean against the needs of its people. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers exist — the maneaba, the democracy, the international partners — with the honest qualifiers that the development need is real, the nation is sovereign and poor, conservation must be made to pay, and there is no victory to promise, only a harder and more honest fight to make protection serve the people. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it must be used. It is for the person — an islander, a member of an affected community, or a respectful ally — who understands that in Kiribati the fight for the ocean is not against a villain but alongside a poor and proud nation weighing genuine needs, and who is willing to do the harder work of making protection affordable rather than the easier work of denouncing a hard choice. That is not a lesser form of advocacy but the only one that can succeed here, and the only one this guide can honestly recommend. Anyone hoping to shame Kiribati into conservation should understand that a struggling, sovereign nation will rightly reject such pressure, and that the real path runs through the maneaba, the democracy, and the patient building of funded protection. This guide is an honest map of that harder path — the path of serving the ocean and the people as one cause.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to defend a marine reserve, a reef, a lagoon, or a fishery:



These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The ecological and livelihood evidence feeds the maneaba, the Assembly, and the international partners at once; the community deliberates collectively; a resolution in the maneaba or an approach to a conservation partner is both pressure and a spur to the next. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still difficult — chance of defending the ocean in a nation that must weigh it against real need.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Kiribati's — a customary culture of collective decision, a democracy, a globally significant ocean, and deep dependence on international partners — give communities a distinctive set:

- **The maneaba.** The **traditional meeting-house and its collective decision-making** is the heart of I-Kiribati governance, and a community's first and most legitimate forum, giving the whole community a voice.
- **The democratic Assembly.** The **elected Maneaba ni Maungatabu** must approve major measures, and is answerable to the people and the islands.
- **The World Heritage and conservation systems.** **UNESCO's World Heritage status and the international conservation partners** can reward, fund, and pressure for protection.
- **The regional bodies.** The **Pacific regional and fisheries bodies** give a small nation collective strength over its ocean.
- **Making conservation pay.** **Conservation finance and sustainable fisheries** are the lever that makes protection serve the people, not oppose them. **Conservation finance and sustainable fisheries** are the lever that makes protection serve the people, not oppose them, and in a poor atoll nation this is, honestly, the decisive one of all.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers prevail, or that conservation beats need here. There is **no community win**; the great marine reserve was **reopened**; the development need is **real**; the nation is **sovereign and poor**; and conservation imposed from outside is **rightly resisted**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly — and shows how to use the real, distinctive tools this nation offers — the maneaba, the democracy, and the international partners — to defend the ocean by making its protection serve the people, honestly acknowledging that need is real and there is no easy victory.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the leverage is real. And map what would be lost and where the maneaba, the Assembly, the World Heritage system, and the conservation partners apply, because in Kiribati a destructive decision is best met not by pitting conservation against the nation's needs, but by bringing the matter to the community's own maneaba, pressing the democratic Assembly, and enlisting the partners who can make protection pay.

The Levels of Decision

A Kiribati decision runs through several tracks, some customary and some modern, and each is a place to intervene.

The government and the Cabinet. The **President and Cabinet** make the great decisions — as the Cabinet decided to reopen the marine reserve — weighing revenue and development, and are answerable, in a democracy, to the Assembly and the people.

The elected Assembly. The **Maneaba ni Maungatabu**, the national parliament named for the meeting-house, must approve major measures, and its members answer to their island communities.

The maneaba. The **local maneaba** — the meeting-house and its collective deliberation — is the customary heart of community decision, where a community forms and voices its collective will, and the most legitimate forum for local opposition.

The World Heritage and conservation systems. UNESCO's **World Heritage status**, and the **international conservation partners and funds**, can reward, finance, and pressure for protection, and can make it pay.

The regional and fisheries bodies. The **Pacific regional and fisheries bodies** give Kiribati collective strength over its tuna and its ocean, and are a lever for sustainable management.

The Journey of a Project

A destructive decision — reopening a reserve, dredging a reef, permitting seabed exploration — moves from a Cabinet or ministry proposal, through the Assembly and administration, toward implementation, with the **community's evidence, the maneaba, the Assembly, and the international partners** able to intervene. **The maneaba and the Assembly are where a community's voice is heard, and the international partners are where protection can be made to pay** — and using them together is the distinctive Kiribati approach. The great question is almost always the same: not whether to develop or protect in the abstract, but **how the people's real needs can be met without destroying the ocean they depend on**. The distinctive levers are the **maneaba**, the **Assembly**, the **World Heritage and conservation partners**, and the **regional bodies**. Find out exactly where the decision stands, and, crucially, **what would be lost, what need is driving it, and how protection might be made to serve that need**, because that is where a destructive decision can be turned.

Follow the Project, the Ocean, and the Deciders

Behind a decision stand the government, the ministry, and often an international partner or a foreign fishing interest. Trace who decides, who benefits, and — importantly here — **what reef, lagoon, fishery, or reserve would be lost, what revenue or development need is driving the decision, how the maneaba and the Assembly can be engaged, and how conservation partners might make protection pay**. Two questions unlock most Kiribati efforts: **What would be lost, and what need is driving its loss?** and **How can that need be met while protecting the ocean — through the maneaba, the Assembly, and the partners?** Making protection serve the people's need is the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in a Kiribati effort ultimately serves this: the documentation exists to show both the loss and the need, the maneaba exists to form the community's collective will around meeting both, and the partners exist to supply the funding that makes protection affordable. Keep the twin aims — protecting the ocean and serving the people — at the centre of every deliberation, every submission, and every proposal, and the effort retains a clear and honest spine that a poor, sovereign nation can embrace rather than resent.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a decision, because they are levers. The **Cabinet and the Assembly**; the **local maneaba** and its collective authority; **UNESCO and the World Heritage Committee**; the **international conservation partners and funds**; the **Pacific regional and fisheries bodies**; and the **churches and community institutions** that hold moral weight in island life. In Kiribati, the **maneaba, the Assembly, the World Heritage and conservation partners, and the regional bodies** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate front, and a destructive decision whose loss is documented, whose driving need is honestly addressed, and which is opposed through the maneaba, the Assembly, and the partners who can fund protection, can sometimes be turned or reshaped — though, honestly, when the need is great and the funding short, protection has been reversed, as the Phoenix Islands were, and this guide will keep saying so.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here honesty means acknowledging that when the nation's need is great and protection does not pay, conservation has lost, as the marine reserve's reopening showed. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how conservation-and-development conflicts have gone in Kiribati and comparable Pacific nations, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the community can **bring the matter to the maneaba as a collective decision**, whether it can **press the democratic Assembly**, and whether it can **enlist the partners who make protection pay** — because appeals to conserve, against real need and without funding, tend to fail here. Where protection can be made to serve the people, the levers are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the nation is poor and sovereign, the need is genuine, and conservation imposed from outside is resisted.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	10–20%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Ecology & livelihood case	35–55%	weeks–months	low	The loss and the stakes, established
The maneaba (collective decision)	40–60%	weeks–months	low	A community's united, legitimate voice
The democratic Assembly	30–50%	months	low	A measure questioned, shaped, or refused
Making conservation pay	40–60%	months–years	moderate	Protection funded to serve the people
World Heritage & partners	30–50%	months–years	low	Recognition, funding, and pressure
All steps (protection made to pay)	40–60%	months–years	moderate	Protected, reshaped, or a need met
Conservation vs. need, unfunded	10–25%	months	low	Usually lost, as the reserve was

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Kiribati's real strengths are distinctive: the **maneaba**, the **Assembly**, the **World Heritage and conservation partners**, and the **regional bodies**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the nation is **poor and sovereign**, the development need is **real**, conservation funding has **fallen short**, and protection imposed from outside is **resisted** — so protection prevails here only when it is made to serve, not oppose, the people.

*A note on cost: the levers here — a maneaba deliberation, a case to the Assembly, an approach to a conservation partner — cost mainly organisation and knowledge rather than money for the community itself. But the deeper cost is real: protection must be paid for, through conservation finance, sustainable-fishery revenue, or livelihoods, or the nation cannot afford it. The scarce resource is **funded protection that meets the people's needs** — which is why enlisting the partners who can supply it is central, and why appeals to conserve without funding tend to fail. This inverts the usual economics of the fights in this series in an instructive way. In most countries, the community's own scarce resources — its organisation, its courage, its persistence — are what the effort most needs, and money is a secondary concern. In Kiribati, the community's organisation is, in a sense, already provided by the maneaba, and the courage required is modest because the state is not repressive; what is genuinely scarce, and genuinely decisive, is the funding*

Effectiveness Visualization

CONSERVATION VS. REAL NEED, UNFUNDED - usually lost:

All steps combined:	■■■■■	10-25%
A reshaping / a partial gain:	■■■■■■■	sometimes achievable
The case / the record made:	■■■■■■■■■	more reliable than a stop
Appeals to conserve alone:	■■	10-25% and often lost

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

- ## What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **Protection must pay, or it falls** — the reserve was reopened when its funding fell short. **The maneaba is decisive** — a community's collective voice, formed in the meeting-house, carries real legitimacy. **Sovereignty is real and respected** — a poor nation rightly resists imposed conservation. **Partners matter** — funding and recognition from abroad can make protection affordable. **Banaba warns** — extraction can devastate an island forever, and that memory has weight. The through-line: **document the loss and the driving need; bring the matter to the maneaba as a collective decision; press the Assembly; and above all make protection pay through conservation partners and sustainable livelihoods** — because a community that does can defend the ocean by making its protection serve the people, while being honest that need is real, sovereignty is respected, and unfunded

conservation usually loses.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact decision and harm that govern the threat — and the leverage the community holds, which here is the maneaba, the democracy, and the partners who can make protection pay. Vague concern goes nowhere, and conservation appeals that ignore the nation's need tend to fail; an effort aimed at "the reopening of this reserve, which would harm this fishery and this reef, driven by a revenue shortfall that conservation finance could instead meet, and which the maneaba and the Assembly can weigh" is a real, honest effort — the kind that can actually turn a decision here. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

- 1. What would be lost?** This is the first question here. What **ecological and livelihood harm** would the decision do — the reef, the lagoon, the fishery, the marine reserve — as the Phoenix Islands' reopening threatens tuna, reefs, and deep-sea habitats.
- 2. What need is driving it?** What **revenue or development need** — as the reserve was reopened for fishing revenue — is driving the decision, since meeting that need honestly is the key to turning it.
- 3. Can protection be made to pay?** How might **conservation finance, sustainable fisheries, or livelihoods** make protection serve the people rather than oppose them, as the reserve's endowment was meant to but failed to.
- 4. How can the maneaba and Assembly be engaged?** How can the **community's collective voice in the maneaba** and the **elected Assembly** be brought to weigh the decision.
- 5. Which partners and bodies can help?** Which **conservation partners, World Heritage bodies, and regional and fisheries bodies** can fund, recognise, and support protection.

A Worked Example

Suppose a marine reserve is to be reopened to fishing, or a reef dredged for development, to meet a revenue or infrastructure need.

Working the five questions: **what would be lost? What need is driving it? Can protection be made to pay? How can the maneaba and Assembly be engaged?** And which partners can help? The deciders are the Cabinet, the Assembly, and the ministries, with the maneaba, the Assembly, the partners, and funded protection as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "the nation needs the revenue and there is nothing to be done" to a real effort: document the loss and the need; bring it to the maneaba; press the Assembly; and — decisively — enlist partners to make protection pay for the need it would otherwise cost. That is an honest effort suited to Kiribati — one that meets the nation's need rather than ignoring it. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they differ from the questions one would ask in a wealthier or a more repressive country: they place the nation's genuine need at the very centre of the analysis, rather than treating it as an obstacle to be overcome or an excuse to be exposed. The loss is documented, yes — but so is the need that drives the decision, and the funded alternative that might meet it, because in Kiribati these are not secondary considerations but the heart of the matter. This reframing — from 'how do we stop this decision' to 'how do we meet the need behind this decision without the loss' — is the single most important move a

Kiribati effort makes, because it converts a confrontation that a poor nation would win into a shared problem that the community, the Assembly, and the partners can solve together. It is the difference between opposing the people and joining them.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, where the case must persuade a community in the maneaba, an elected Assembly, and conservation partners, sound evidence of both the loss and the need is decisive. The maneaba, a member of the Assembly, and a conservation funder all move on evidence — and in Kiribati, a clear record of what would be lost, what need drives the decision, and how protection could meet that need is precisely what an effort turns into a real result, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Decision, the Need, and the Deciders

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **decision, the ministry or Cabinet behind it, the reef, fishery, or reserve it affects, and the process it requires** — and, crucially here, the **need driving it**: the revenue, the development, the shortfall, as the reserve's reopening was driven by lost fishing revenue and a conservation fund that underdelivered. Establish the deciders and the driving need precisely, because in Kiribati you cannot turn a decision without honestly addressing the need behind it.

Layer 2: The Loss — to Reefs, Fisheries, and the Future

Document what would be lost. Establish the **ecological harm** — to reefs, lagoons, tuna and fish stocks, marine mammals and birds, and the deep-sea and reef ecosystems, as the Phoenix Islands hold. And establish the **livelihood harm** — to the fishery the people depend on, to the food security of island communities, to the tourism and future the ocean sustains. Draw on **the conservation partners' science, the World Heritage documentation, and local knowledge**. And let **Banaba's devastation** stand as documented warning of what unchecked extraction can do to an island forever. Banaba's history deserves to be understood and invoked with care, because it is both a genuine warning and a delicate matter. Over decades, the phosphate of Banaba was mined until much of the island's surface was stripped away, and its people were resettled far from their home, on another island in another country, their island left barely habitable — a stark and well-documented example of how the extraction of an island's one valuable resource can destroy the island itself and displace its people permanently. Invoked honestly, this history is a powerful reminder, in a nation now weighing the exploitation of its ocean and its seabed, of what can be lost forever when a resource is taken without limit. But it must be invoked with respect for the Banaban people, whose loss is real and whose story is their own, and as a shared cautionary memory rather than a rhetorical weapon — a reminder to a proud nation, from its own history, of the permanence of some losses. Photographs, scientific data, and local testimony make the loss undeniable.

Layer 3: The Loss, the Need, the Funded Alternative, and the Channel

Finally, document the case. Does the **ecological and livelihood harm** show a real loss? What **need** drives the decision? Could **conservation finance, sustainable fisheries, or livelihoods** meet that need while protecting the ocean — the funded alternative that is the heart of a Kiribati case? And which **channel** — the maneaba, the Assembly, the partners — is open? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case that can persuade a community and a nation that must weigh the ocean against its needs. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented loss, an honestly-addressed need, a

funded alternative, and an open channel are exactly what let a Kiribati community defend the ocean without opposing the people. Build it well, and the maneaba, the democracy, and the funded alternative become the community's strength. One practical note on building this layer: the funded alternative is the part of the file that a Kiribati effort most often neglects and most needs, because it is the part that answers the government's actual reason for the destructive decision. It is not enough to document the ecological value of a reef or a reserve, however rigorously; the file must also grapple honestly with the revenue or development need the decision serves, and set out a credible way to meet that need without the loss. This means understanding, concretely, how much revenue is at stake, what a conservation endowment or a debt-for-nature swap or a sustainable-fishery arrangement could realistically provide, and why previous funding models — like the Phoenix Islands endowment that raised only a fraction of what was hoped — fell short, so the new proposal is realistic rather than aspirational. A file that pairs a rigorous account of the loss with a credible, funded alternative speaks directly to the deciders' real dilemma, and is far more persuasive than one that documents only what would be lost.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists. Here is where the material tends to live in a Kiribati effort, and how to get it — with the **loss**, the **driving need**, the **funded alternative**, and the **maneaba and partner channels** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Decision and Need Record

Start with the decision itself. **Cabinet statements, ministry documents, and any Assembly measures** establish what is intended and where it stands; the government's own statements often set out the **need** driving it, as the reserve's reopening was explained by lost revenue and an underfunded endowment. Establish exactly **what the decision is, who is behind it, and what need drives it**, because the need is the thing a Kiribati effort must honestly meet, and understanding it precisely is the key to offering a funded alternative.

The Ecological and Livelihood Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **ecological evidence** — the state of the reefs, lagoons, fisheries, and marine reserve, drawing on **conservation partners' science, World Heritage documentation, and fisheries data**, much of which already exists for a site as studied as the Phoenix Islands. And gather the **livelihood evidence** — the community's dependence on the fishery and the reef for food and income, the stakes for island life. Let **Banaba's history** stand as documented warning. Photographs, scientific studies, and local knowledge make both the ecological loss and the human stakes vivid and credible.

The Funded-Alternative Record

Document the alternative, because this is the distinctive and decisive Kiribati lever. Establish how the **need might be met without destroying the ocean**: what **conservation finance** — endowments, debt-for-nature swaps, blue-economy funds, payments for protection — might replace lost revenue; what **sustainable-fishery revenue** might be earned without dismantling protection; what **livelihoods** might be built. Learn from why the reserve's endowment fell short, so a new alternative is realistic. A community that can show a funded way to meet the need while protecting the ocean holds the one argument that can actually prevail in a poor nation.

The Channels and Partners

Identify the channels and allies. The **maneaba** — the local meeting-house — is the customary channel for forming and voicing the community's collective will. The **elected Assembly** is the democratic channel for major measures. The **World Heritage bodies and conservation partners** — the funders, the scientists, the international organisations — can recognise, fund, and support protection. The **regional and fisheries bodies** give collective strength over the tuna and the ocean. Map which apply, because in Kiribati the maneaba and the funding partners together are the levers that can make protection serve the people.

The People and the Community

Finally, map the human terrain. Who is affected — the island communities, the fishers, the future generations? Who holds authority — the **unimwane**, the elders, in the maneaba; the **church**, a central moral force in island life; the **Assembly members** answerable to their islands? Who abroad can help — the **conservation partners, the diaspora, the regional bodies**? A Kiribati effort is advanced through the community's own institutions — the maneaba, the elders, the church — joined to the international partners who can fund protection, so map that coalition, customary and international together, deliberately.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Evidence does not move deciders by itself. A community — united, informed, and speaking through its own maneaba — is what turns evidence into a legitimate collective voice, in a culture where collective decision is the very heart of governance. And here, distinctively, the community already has an ancient institution for exactly this: the maneaba, the meeting-house where the community deliberates and forms its united will. The task is not to invent opposition, but to bring the matter, properly, to the maneaba.

Why the Community Is Decisive — and Speaks Through the Maneaba

In I-Kiribati culture, the maneaba is where the community's collective will is formed and voiced, and a decision reached there carries deep legitimacy. The community supplies what an effort runs on: the affected voices, the local and ecological knowledge, the legitimacy, and the collective authority that the maneaba embodies. A concern carried by one person is easily set aside; a concern deliberated and voiced by the maneaba, as the united will of the community, is not. **A united community here does not merely support the effort; through the maneaba, it becomes the effort's legitimate collective voice — the most authentic and powerful form opposition can take in Kiribati.** This is a genuinely distinctive feature of the Kiribati situation, and it changes the character of the whole effort. In many countries, a community must construct its opposition from scratch, building organisation and legitimacy where none existed; in Kiribati, an ancient and deeply respected institution for collective decision already exists in every community — the maneaba, where islanders have deliberated and decided together for generations. The effort's task is therefore not to invent a movement but to bring the matter properly before this institution, so that the community's response emerges through its own trusted, customary process and carries the full weight of that tradition. A position reached in the maneaba is not one group's campaign but the community's collective will, formed in the way I-Kiribati have always formed such wills — and that gives it a legitimacy, at home and before the Assembly, that no imported form of protest could match. Working through the maneaba is thus not only culturally respectful but strategically powerful.

Bringing the Matter to the Maneaba

Begin by bringing the decision, honestly, to the **maneaba** — the meeting-house of the affected island or community. Lay out what would be lost, what need drives the decision, and what funded alternative might meet that need, so the community can deliberate as it traditionally does, weighing the ocean against the

need with full knowledge. Respect the **unimwane**, the elders whose voice carries weight, and the customary process of consensus. Name the shared stake — **our reef, our fishery, our ocean, and our children's future, and how to keep them without failing our needs** — because in the maneaba the community can forge a collective position that honours both the ocean and the people. This dual honouring — of the ocean and of the people's needs — is essential to how a matter must be brought to the maneaba, because the maneaba is not a place for one-sided advocacy but for weighing the whole community's interests together. A person who comes to the meeting-house demanding conservation while ignoring the community's need for income or food will not carry the maneaba; the community lives with those needs daily and will not set them aside. But a person who lays out honestly both what would be lost and how the need behind the decision might still be met — through a funded alternative, a sustainable fishery, a livelihood — invites the maneaba to do what it does best: to find, through collective deliberation, a path that serves the whole community. The maneaba is far more likely to unite behind protection that also feeds the people than behind conservation that seems to ignore them, so the matter must always be brought as a question of holding both, never of choosing the ocean over the community's survival.

Coalition-Building Through Custom and Partnership

A community allied is stronger than a community alone, and in Kiribati the coalition joins custom to partnership. Reach to the **elders and the maneaba** of neighbouring communities; the **church**, whose moral voice carries far in island life; the **Assembly members** answerable to the islands; and — decisively for the funded alternative — the **conservation partners, World Heritage bodies, and regional organisations** who can make protection pay. Frame the coalition around a shared defence of the ocean that also serves the people, uniting custom, faith, democracy, and international partnership. Breadth here means joining the community's own institutions to the partners who can fund protection.

Sustaining the Effort

Kiribati efforts can be sustained through the community's own institutions and the rhythms of island life. Keep the community **informed and united through the maneaba**; mark steps — a maneaba resolution, a matter raised in the Assembly, a conservation partner engaged, a funded alternative advanced. And keep the effort grounded in the community's needs, not against them, because an effort that pits conservation against the people's survival will lose the maneaba itself. The effort that lasts is the one that stays united through the maneaba, joined to the partners who can fund protection, and always honest about meeting the people's needs. Sustaining such an effort is helped, in Kiribati, by the very rhythms of island and maneaba life, in which the community regularly gathers and deliberates, so that a matter can be kept before the community over time through its ordinary customary processes rather than requiring some separate campaign to be maintained. But it is also challenged by the smallness and remoteness of island communities and the constant pressure of real need, which can wear down resolve when protection seems to cost more than the community can bear. The answer is to keep the funded alternative always at the centre — to be able to show, at each gathering, progress toward making protection something the community can actually afford — because a community sustained by the visible prospect of protection that serves its needs will endure, while one asked to sacrifice indefinitely for an unfunded conservation will not.

STEP 4: LEGAL, CUSTOMARY & INTERNATIONAL CHALLENGES — THE MANEABA, THE ASSEMBLY, AND THE WORLD HERITAGE SYSTEM

This is where a Kiribati effort is realistically advanced — not through confrontation, but through the **maneaba's customary authority, the democratic Assembly, and the international World Heritage and conservation systems**, all bent toward making protection serve the people. Here the customary, legal, and international levers come together, because in Kiribati the community's own institutions and the international partners are, together, how the ocean is defended.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real but bounded by the nation's need and sovereignty**. The maneaba carries **deep legitimacy but not legal veto** over national decisions; the Assembly is **democratic but weighs revenue heavily**; and the World Heritage and conservation systems can **recognise, fund, and pressure but not override a sovereign choice** — and imposed conservation is resisted. What these levers realistically achieve is **a legitimate collective voice, a measure questioned or reshaped, protection funded, and recognition defended** — not usually the simple overriding of a decision driven by real need. Enter this front clear-eyed: the maneaba, the Assembly, and the international systems are Kiribati's distinctive levers, strongest when protection is **made to serve the people** — but the need is real, and unfunded conservation is often reversed.

The Maneaba and Customary Authority

The first and most distinctive front is the maneaba. The **meeting-house and its collective deliberation** are the customary heart of I-Kiribati decision, and a community's united position, formed in the maneaba and voiced by its elders, carries a legitimacy that national deciders cannot lightly ignore. Bring the matter to the maneaba; forge a collective position that honours both the ocean and the people's needs; and carry that united voice to the Assembly and the government. This customary authority is the community's most authentic and powerful lever, because it speaks with the whole community's legitimacy. It is worth being clear about both the strength and the limit of this lever, honestly. Its strength is legitimacy: a position reached in the maneaba is the authentic collective will of the community, and no national decider can dismiss it as the agitation of a fringe, because it is the community itself speaking through its most trusted institution. Its limit is authority: the maneaba's legitimacy is moral and customary, not a legal veto over national decisions, and a determined government weighing national revenue can proceed despite a community's maneaba even as it takes a political cost for doing so. Understanding both is essential — the maneaba gives a community a voice of unmatched authenticity and weight, but that voice persuades and pressures rather than compels, which is precisely why it must be joined to the Assembly's decision-making power and the partners' funding to become fully effective.

The Democratic Assembly

The second front is the democracy. The **Maneaba ni Maungatabu**, the elected national parliament, must approve major measures — as the reserve's reopening required — and its members answer to their island communities. Bring the community's maneaba-formed position to **sympathetic members**; press for the decision to be debated, questioned, and reshaped; and, crucially, offer the **funded alternative** that lets members serve both conservation and their constituents' needs. The Assembly weighs revenue heavily, so the argument that wins there is not conservation against need, but protection that meets the need. This is worth stating as plainly as possible, because it is where many well-meaning efforts fail: an Assembly member from a poor island constituency cannot vote to forgo revenue their constituents depend on merely because a reef or a reserve is ecologically precious, however genuinely they may value it. To ask them to do so is to ask them to fail the very people who elected them, and they will not, and should not. But to offer them a funded alternative — a way to protect the ocean while still delivering to their constituents the revenue

or the livelihoods they need — is to give them a vote they can actually cast, one that serves both their islands and the sea. The entire art of moving the Assembly in Kiribati lies in this: never forcing a choice between the ocean and the people, but always supplying the funded path that lets a member choose both.

The World Heritage and Conservation Systems

The third front is international. **UNESCO's World Heritage status** — which the Phoenix Islands hold, and which their reopening puts at risk — is a lever of international recognition and pressure, and its loss is a real cost a nation may wish to avoid. The **international conservation partners and funds** can, decisively, make protection pay — through endowments, debt-for-nature swaps, blue-economy finance, and payments for protection — meeting the very need that drives destruction. And the **regional and fisheries bodies** give collective strength over the tuna. Pursued together — the maneaba's legitimacy, the Assembly's decision, and the international partners' funding — these fronts are how a Kiribati community defends the ocean by making its protection serve, rather than oppose, the people. It is worth understanding why these three fronts must work together, because each supplies what the others lack. The maneaba supplies legitimacy — the authentic, collective voice of the community — but it cannot fund protection or bind a national decision. The Assembly supplies the legal decision — it can approve, reshape, or refuse a measure — but it weighs revenue heavily and answers to a nation's needs. And the international partners supply the funding — the conservation finance that can make protection affordable — but they cannot, and must not, override a sovereign choice. Woven together — a community united in the maneaba, an Assembly offered a funded way to serve both its constituents and the ocean, and partners ready to pay for protection — they form a combination that can defend the ocean without asking a poor nation to choose between the sea and its survival. The failure of the Phoenix Islands protection was, in a sense, a failure of this combination: the conservation was real and the legitimacy was there, but the funding fell short, and so protection could not be sustained. A Kiribati effort must get all three right.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them — and here, above all, in the language of serving the people while protecting the ocean. The same file of loss, need, and funded alternative becomes different arguments for the maneaba, the Assembly, a conservation partner, and the wider world. Translate deliberately.

For the Maneaba

The maneaba responds to **the community's shared stake and its collective wisdom**. Frame the decision as a matter for the community's own deliberation: here is what would be lost — our reef, our fishery, our children's ocean; here is the need driving it; and here is a way to meet that need without the loss. Give the elders and the community the full picture, and let the maneaba forge its collective will. Speak with respect for custom and consensus: *this is our ocean and our need together, and here is how we might hold both*.

For the Assembly

Assembly members respond to **their constituents' needs and the nation's revenue**. Frame the case not as conservation against development, but as protection that serves the people: here is the loss, here is the need, and here is the funded alternative that meets the need while keeping the ocean. Give members the maneaba's united voice and a realistic funded path, so protecting the ocean becomes the choice that also serves their islands. The argument that wins is one that meets the need, not one that ignores it.

For the Conservation Partners

The partners respond to a **fundable, credible opportunity to make protection pay**. Give them sound science, a clear conservation value, and a realistic plan to meet the nation's need through finance — learning from why the earlier endowment fell short. The partners' funding is the lever that makes protection affordable, so bring them a credible way to fund the alternative that the nation requires.

For the Region and the World

The regional bodies and the world respond to **shared ocean stewardship and global significance**. Frame the case as the defence of a globally significant ocean and a World Heritage site, and as a matter of Pacific solidarity over shared tuna and shared seas — but always with respect for Kiribati's sovereignty, never as conservation imposed from outside. Give them the global stakes and the regional interest, so their support strengthens rather than overrides the nation's own choice.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, and never ignore the people's real need. Your credibility is your greatest asset, and in a small nation it is quickly tested. State the loss precisely, address the need honestly, and offer a realistic funded alternative. And respect sovereignty: frame every argument as helping Kiribati protect its own ocean for its own people, never as outsiders dictating. A community that is precise, honest about need, and respectful of sovereignty is far harder to dismiss than one that lectures a struggling nation.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — but in Kiribati, the story must be told with care, honouring both the ocean and the nation's real needs, and mindful that heavy-handed international pressure can be resented as neo-colonial. The story — a poor nation weighing its globally significant ocean against its people's needs — is one that can move both islanders and the world, if told with honesty and respect.

Why Media Matters

The government, the Assembly, the partners, and the world behave differently when a decision is visible and its stakes are clear. Media does three things here: it **informs and unites the community and the public**, it **draws the conservation partners and funding** that can make protection pay, and it **raises the stakes** of losing a globally significant ocean and a World Heritage site. But media here must be careful: a story that shames a poor nation for weighing its own survival will backfire and be resented; a story that shows a nation striving to protect its ocean while meeting its people's needs, and calls on partners to help make that possible, will succeed. The frame must honour Kiribati's sovereignty and needs. This is not merely a matter of tact but of effectiveness, because the international attention that helps a conservation cause elsewhere can actively harm one in Kiribati if it is framed as the rich world scolding a poor nation for its choices. The government has itself rejected such framing as neo-colonial, and it is right to resent outsiders who have never faced its dilemmas presuming to lecture it about its own ocean. The media strategy that works is the one that presents Kiribati not as a villain to be shamed but as a nation facing an unfair choice — between its ocean and its people's needs — that the wealthier world, which benefits from healthy oceans and bears much responsibility for the climate that threatens these islands, ought to help it avoid. That framing invites partnership and funding rather than provoking defensive resistance, and it is both more honest and more effective.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the ocean and the people together. The strongest frame is honest and unifying: *this is one of the world's great oceans and a World Heritage site, and a poor nation is being forced to choose between protecting it and feeding its people — a choice that partners could help it not have to make*. Put the shared stake and the real dilemma first, and call on the world to help make protection pay, rather than to condemn. Keep it scrupulously accurate and respectful; in a small, proud nation, a story that lectures will be rejected. The Kiribati story is powerful because the dilemma is real and the ocean is genuinely precious.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience. **Local radio and the maneaba networks** for the community; the **national media** for the public and the Assembly; the **regional Pacific media** for solidarity over shared seas; and the **international conservation and news media** for the partners and the global stakes — used respectfully, to call for help rather than to shame. Because Kiribati's decision turns on both community feeling and international funding, both the customary-national and the international channels matter — the first to unite the people, the second to fund the alternative.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, respectful, and honest about need — the goal is to defend the ocean while serving the people, not to shame a poor nation. Frame every story around meeting the nation's needs, not overriding them, and honour Kiribati's sovereignty, because heavy-handed international pressure is rightly resented and will backfire. Protect the community's own voice through the maneaba, and let islanders speak for their ocean. And sustain the story with the funded alternatives and the real stakes. Above all, let the honest dilemma — a precious ocean, a poor nation, and a way to hold both — carry the story, because that is where a Kiribati effort is strongest and most true.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real decision, the real loss, and the real need, keep it factual, and always honour the nation's needs and sovereignty. Here honesty about need, and respect, win.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request for information — [decision] and its assessment

Dear [official],

I am writing on behalf of [community/maneaba] regarding [decision] affecting [reef/fishery/reserve]. To understand and respond to this matter, we request the **relevant decisions and documents**, the **assessment** of ecological and livelihood impacts, and information on the **revenue or development need** the decision is intended to meet. We wish to help find a way to serve our people's needs while protecting our ocean.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8B: Bringing the Matter to the Maneaba

Subject: A matter for our maneaba — [decision] and our ocean

To the unimwane and community of [maneaba],

We bring before the maneaba a matter affecting our [reef/fishery/reserve]: [decision], which would [harm], driven by [need]. We ask the community to deliberate, in our custom, on what would be lost, on the need behind it, and on whether a funded alternative might meet that need while protecting our ocean. We seek the community's collective wisdom and united voice on how to hold both our needs and our ocean.

With respect,

[Name, community]

8C: Letter to an Assembly Member

Subject: Serving our islands while protecting our ocean — [decision]

Dear [Member],

We write as constituents regarding [decision], which would [harm] our [reef/fishery/reserve]. We understand the need for [revenue/development], and we do not ask you to ignore it — we ask you to help meet it another way: through [funded alternative], so our people's needs are served without losing our ocean. Our maneaba has deliberated and shares this view. We would welcome the chance to discuss how protection might be funded to serve our islands.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8D: Letter to a Conservation Partner

Subject: Making protection pay for [place] in Kiribati

Dear [conservation organisation / fund],

Our community seeks to protect [reef/fishery/reserve], a site of [ecological/global significance], but our nation faces a real need for [revenue/development] that makes protection hard to afford — as the reopening of the Phoenix Islands showed. We ask your partnership to make protection pay: through [conservation finance / debt-for-nature / blue economy / sustainable fisheries]. We can provide documentation, and we seek a realistic, lasting funded model that meets our people's needs.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8E: Media Pitch

Subject: A poor nation, a world-heritage ocean, and a choice partners could help avoid

Dear [journalist],

In Kiribati, [decision] would [harm] [a globally significant ocean / World Heritage site], driven not by greed but by a poor nation's real need for [revenue]. There is an important, honest story here — a nation forced to choose between its ocean and its people, and how partners could help it not have to. We can provide the ecology, the stakes, and community voices, told with respect for our nation's needs.

Sincerely,

[Name, community, contact]

8F: Letter to a Regional or World Heritage Body

Subject: Support to protect [place] while serving Kiribati's needs

Dear [Pacific body / World Heritage Centre],

We write regarding [decision] affecting [place], of [regional/global significance]. We respectfully seek your support — recognition, funding, and solidarity — to help our nation protect this ocean while meeting its people's needs, never to override our sovereign choice but to help make protection affordable. We can provide documentation and welcome your partnership.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8G: Letter to the Church

Subject: Our ocean, our people, and our stewardship

Dear [church leader],

Our community faces [decision], which would harm our [reef/fishery/ocean] that God has given us to steward and that feeds our people. We seek to protect it while honouring our people's real needs. We ask the church's moral voice and support in uniting our community to hold both our stewardship of creation and the wellbeing of our people. Might we discuss how the church can help?

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8H: Rallying the Community

Subject: Our reef, our fishery, our future — let us decide together

Dear neighbours,

[Decision] would harm [place] — our reef, our fishery, the ocean that feeds us. We know our people have real needs, and we do not ignore them; we seek a way to meet them while keeping our ocean. Let us gather in the maneaba, deliberate in our custom, and forge our united voice — and let us call on our partners to help make protecting our ocean serve our people. Together, we can hold both our needs and our sea.

With respect,

[Name, community]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a decision is moving fast — a Cabinet decision made, a measure before the Assembly — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest here, which means the maneaba, a sympathetic Assembly member, and a conservation partner.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials: **what the decision is, what would be lost, and what need is driving it.** Identify the immediate pressure point — an **Assembly vote, a Cabinet decision, a permit** — because that is what you must affect first. Bring the matter to the **maneaba** at once, because in Kiribati the community's collective voice, formed in the meeting-house, is the fastest route to legitimate weight — and contact a **conservation partner**, because a funded alternative is the fastest way to meet the need behind the decision.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **The maneaba's collective voice** can form quickly and carries immediate legitimacy. **A sympathetic Assembly member** can raise or question a measure at once. **A conservation partner's offer to fund protection** can change the calculation fast, by meeting the need. **The risk of losing World Heritage status** is an immediate cost a nation may weigh. These outpace the slower work of building funded models — though that work must follow, because only funded protection lasts. The sequence matters here: the fast levers can win a pause — a decision delayed, a measure sent back for reconsideration, a vote postponed — but a pause won without a funded alternative to follow is only a reprieve, because the underlying need remains and will reassert itself, as it did with the Phoenix Islands. So even in an emergency, the first fast moves must be paired with an immediate approach to conservation partners, so that the pause bought by the maneaba and the Assembly can be filled, before it expires, with the beginnings of a funded model that actually meets the need. Speed buys time; only funding makes protection last.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but here you can convene the maneaba and reach key allies fast. Bring the matter to the **maneaba and the elders**; reach a **sympathetic Assembly member, the church, and a conservation partner**. A community united in the maneaba, offering a funded way to meet the need, at the moment of decision, is the most rapid Kiribati effort can do — and often enough to win a pause. Speed favours the prepared: know the loss, the need, and a funded alternative before the decision falls.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the system is tilted not by corruption or repression but by poverty and dependence — a poor, remote nation that must weigh every acre of ocean against its people's survival, and that depends on fishing revenue for most of its income. This is Kiribati's central, honest truth, and the whole guide has been shaped by it. Name it plainly, because pretending the choice is easy, or that need does not weigh heavily, would be false.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are the ordinary condition of a poor atoll nation. **Revenue need is paramount** — fishing licences supply most of the government's income. **Conservation must compete with survival** — a reserve closed is revenue forgone. **Funding for protection has fallen short** — the reserve's endowment underdelivered. **Sovereignty is fiercely held** — imposed conservation is resented. This is not a tilt of villainy but of genuine need, and an effort here must be built to meet that need, not to override it.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted by poverty, tilt it back with funding and legitimacy, not lectures. Lean on the **maneaba's collective legitimacy**, the **Assembly's accountability**, and above all the **conservation partners who can make protection pay** — meeting the need that drives destruction. Aim realistically at

protection funded to serve the people, decisions reshaped, and losses averted where an alternative is found, rather than at conservation imposed against need. Respect sovereignty, and frame every effort as helping the nation protect its own ocean. And build the funded models even slowly, because a durable, funded alternative is the only thing that makes protection last in a poor nation — the very lesson the reserve's reopening taught. A field tilted by poverty is shifted not by pressure but by making protection affordable. This is perhaps the single most important strategic insight for Kiribati, and it distinguishes this fight from almost every other in this series. In a wealthy or a repressive country, the obstacle to protection is often political will or state power, to be moved by pressure, law, or exposure. In a poor atoll nation, the obstacle is frequently just money — the plain fact that a small, low-income country cannot afford to forgo the revenue that its ocean's exploitation provides. Pressure does not solve this; only funding does. A campaign that grasps this will spend less of its energy denouncing the decision and more of it assembling the conservation finance, the sustainable-fishery revenue, and the livelihood alternatives that would let the nation afford to protect its ocean. The reopening of the Phoenix Islands was, at bottom, a funding failure, and the surest way to prevent the next such reversal is to build, patiently and in genuine partnership, the financial models that make protection something a poor nation can actually sustain.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may lose — a reserve may stay open, a reef may be lost — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the Phoenix Islands were reopened despite their fame, because the need was real and the funding short. If protection is lost, the work is still not wasted: the **loss was documented, the community united through the maneaba, the funded alternatives advanced, the record made, and the next effort — and the next funding model — starts stronger**. And the deeper work continues: building the conservation finance and sustainable livelihoods that will let a poor nation afford to protect its ocean. Fight to protect this place; if you lose, keep building the funded models that will let the nation choose protection next time, because in Kiribati the long victory is making conservation something the people can afford.

WHEN IT'S NOT CORRUPTION — AND WHY THE OBSTACLE IS USUALLY NEED

In some countries this section would concern corruption; in Kiribati, honestly, the obstacle is usually not graft but genuine poverty, real development need, and fiercely-held sovereignty. The reserve was reopened not to enrich the powerful but because a poor nation depended on the revenue and the promised conservation funding fell short. Recognising this honestly matters, because the response to genuine need is utterly different from the response to corruption.

Telling Need from Wrongdoing

A poor nation weighing its ocean against its people's survival, and resisting conservation imposed from outside, is not corrupt — and treating it as such would be both false and deeply insulting to a proud, struggling nation. The real obstacle here is honest: **poverty, revenue dependence, underfunded conservation, and sovereignty**. Be rigorous and respectful: **do not mistake a poor nation's hard, sovereign choice for corruption**. That said, small and dependent states can face real pressures — opaque foreign fishing deals, geopolitical influence over resource decisions, patronage — and where a specific decision is genuinely tainted rather than merely driven by need, that can be examined through the Assembly, the press, and regional transparency mechanisms. But approach even this carefully and factually, and expect, mostly, an honest obstacle of need, to be met not by exposure but by funded alternatives that serve the people.

Responding to the Real Obstacle

An honest obstacle of need calls not for exposure but for funded alternatives and respect. Push the levers that meet the need: the **conservation partners and finance** that make protection pay, the **sustainable fisheries** that earn revenue without dismantling protection, the **livelihoods** that serve island communities. Bring the **maneaba's legitimacy** and the **Assembly's accountability** to bear, and frame everything as helping the nation protect its own ocean for its own people. Where a decision is genuinely tainted, use the democracy's and the region's honest tools; but expect, mostly, a fight not against wrongdoing but against poverty — won by making protection affordable.

A Note on Respect and Care

Kiribati is a democracy and not a repressive state, and the risks here are not those of repression — this is a fight waged in the maneaba, the Assembly, and partnership, not one of danger. But it demands a particular care: respect for a poor, proud, sovereign nation making hard choices. Frame conservation and the people's needs as one cause, never as opposites. Honour the maneaba, the elders, the church, and the customary ways of deciding. Respect sovereignty absolutely, and never let the effort become outsiders dictating to a struggling nation. And carry the deeper work — the funded models — patiently, because that is what truly serves both the ocean and the people. Care here means respect, humility, and the honest labour of making protection affordable.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others. Here is how they fit into a single effort in Kiribati.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together. **Documentation** builds the loss-need-and-alternative file. **Target identification** aims it at the deciders. **Local opposition** unites the community through the maneaba. **Legal, customary, and international** work presses the maneaba's legitimacy, the Assembly's decision, and the partners' funding. **Media** raises the honest dilemma at home and abroad. The loss, the need, and the funded alternative feed all five at once — a documented case is matter for the maneaba, an argument for the Assembly, a proposal for a partner, and a story for the world together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, uniting custom and funding, they compound toward protection that serves the people.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the decision, the loss, and the driving need; bring the matter to the maneaba; identify partners and funded alternatives. **Middle (months 2–12):** unite the community through the maneaba; press the Assembly; develop the funded alternative with conservation partners; engage the World Heritage and regional bodies. **Later (months and years):** secure protection funded to serve the people, or reshape the decision, and build the lasting conservation-finance and livelihood models whatever the single outcome. A Kiribati effort is patient, and its deepest work — making protection affordable — is long; pace it for both the immediate decision and the lasting model.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the loss and the driving need; unite the community through the maneaba; press the Assembly; make protection pay through conservation partners and sustainable livelihoods; and honour the nation's needs and sovereignty throughout.** The community that presses all five, uniting its own customary institutions with the international partners who can fund protection, is the one that can defend the ocean by making its protection serve the people — the only kind of protection that lasts in a poor and sovereign nation.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a destructive decision in Kiribati is genuinely hard, and honestly bound up with the nation's poverty and sovereignty rather than with any villainy, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: there is no community victory, the great marine reserve was reopened, and the development need is real. And yet the effort is not futile, because Kiribati has its own ancient institution of collective decision — the maneaba — a functioning democracy, and international partners who can make protection pay; and the deepest lesson of the Phoenix Islands is not that conservation is impossible here, but that it must be made to serve the people, or it will not last.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **The maneaba is the community's foundation and most legitimate voice, and making protection pay is the distinctive necessity. The Assembly and the international partners are real levers, bent toward meeting the need. But the nation is poor and sovereign, the need is real, and unfunded conservation is often reversed.** Hold both truths at once: real, distinctive levers, and the honest weight of genuine need.

Above all, keep the discipline that gives these efforts their force. Document the loss and the driving need. Unite the community through the maneaba. Press the Assembly. Make protection pay through the partners. And honour the nation's needs and sovereignty always — because in a poor, proud nation, an effort that helps protect the ocean while serving the people is welcomed, and one that lectures a struggling nation is rightly rejected.

The Phoenix Islands — one of the world's great ocean sanctuaries, a World Heritage site of pristine reefs and tuna spawning grounds — were reopened to fishing, because a poor nation depended on the revenue and the fund meant to replace it fell short; and Banaba, long ago, was strip-mined for its phosphate until it could barely be lived on, its people carried away to another shore. This guide has hidden neither loss. its people carried away to another shore, to build a new life on land that was not their own. This guide has hidden neither loss, nor pretended that such things cannot happen again. But the maneaba still gathers, the democracy still answers to the islands, the world still values these oceans, and partners still exist who can make protection pay — and the lesson of these losses is not despair but direction: that in a poor and sovereign nation, the ocean is defended not by lecturing the people but by making its protection serve them. There is no easy victory to promise, and no community precedent of triumph to inherit; this guide has said so throughout. But your reefs, your fisheries, and your ocean are worth defending, your maneaba is a genuine and legitimate power, your democracy answers to your islands, and partners stand ready to help make protection affordable. The way here is not to set conservation against your people, but to make them one cause — and that is a fight worth waging, and one your community, through its own maneaba, can lead. So can you. And the way to lead it is close at hand, in an institution your community already trusts and has trusted for generations. Gather in the maneaba, lay the loss and the need honestly before your people, and let them do what they have always done — deliberate together and forge a united will; then carry that will to your Assembly and to the partners who can help make protecting your ocean something your nation can afford. That is not a borrowed method or an imported protest, but your own way of deciding, turned to the

defence of your reefs and your fisheries and your sea. It has not yet won back the Phoenix Islands, and this guide has not pretended otherwise; but it is a real and living power, and joined to the funding that makes protection affordable, it is how your ocean can be held for your children without failing your people today.